SPOKES

Skills for Life

# Money Management

Part 2: Save Money Before You Spend It -- The Cushion Challenge

## Teacher's Guide

Instructor Speaking Notes, Discussion Prompts & Slide Guide

WIPPEA Lesson Format

This guide walks you through every slide in sequence with speaking notes, discussion prompts to spark class conversation, teaching tips, handout references showing when to distribute materials, and a printable checklist of everything you need before class.

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Strategic Planning in Occupational Knowledge for Employment and Success

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Printable Resources Checklist -- See the final page

# W CHAPTER 1: WARM-UP -- MEET JESS

WARM-UP

## SLIDE 1 -- Meet Jess

Story Intro

**Speaking Notes:**

Part 2 runs about 10 minutes and is taught as one idea through one story. Before class, open The Cushion Challenge on the classroom screen and press Start over.

Play the Meet Jess video at the top of the screen (about one minute, captions on). It introduces Jess, a mom of two who found work through SPOKES, and ends by asking the class to help her.

Then point to the facts on screen: she still gets SNAP, her take-home pay is $400 a week, and every dollar already has a job. Her goal is a small cushion so one bad week does not turn into a crisis.

**[VIDEO] Meet Jess (about one minute, captioned)**

**DISCUSSION PROMPT**

Ask: 'What is one surprise cost families run into?' Take two or three quick answers. Ask for the kind of cost, never the amount.

**TEACHING TIP**

Jess and her numbers are made up on purpose. No one shares their own income, benefits, or balances at any point in Part 2. Say this out loud before you start.

# 1 CHAPTER 2: INTRODUCTION -- THE IDEA

## INTRODUCTION

### SLIDE 1 -- State the Goal

Instructor Talk

**Speaking Notes:**

Give the one idea of Part 2 in a sentence before Payday 1:

'Save a little first, automatically, somewhere safe, so a small cushion protects your family. You can do it while on benefits.'

Point to the cushion meter and its gold goal line at $250. Tell the class they will make Jess's choices for four paydays and watch what each choice does.

> **TEACHING TIP**
>
> How the class votes: show of hands, thumbs up or down, or a spokesperson who picks after a quick poll. Keep votes fast -- about 30 seconds each -- to stay inside 10 minutes.

# P CHAPTER 3: PAYDAYS 1 AND 2

## PRESENTATION

### SLIDE 2 -- Payday 1: When Does Jess Save?

Class Vote

**Speaking Notes:**

Choices: save $10, $25, or $50 first, or save what's left at the end of the week.

If the class picks 'save what's left,' let it play out: by Friday nothing is left. That is the lesson, so no correction is needed.

Pop-up line to say: 'Pay yourself first. Treat savings like a bill you pay the day money arrives. The habit matters more than the amount.'

> **DISCUSSION PROMPT**
>
> Ask: 'Why does saving at the end of the week usually mean saving nothing?'

### SLIDE 3 -- Payday 2: Where Should Jess Keep Her Savings?

Class Vote

**Speaking Notes:**

Choices: a jar at home, an account with a $12 monthly fee and overdraft charges, or a Bank On-style account.

Expected answer: the Bank On-style account. The fee account loses $12 right away. The jar looks fine now, but Jess dips into it on Payday 3.

Pop-up line to say: 'Keep savings somewhere safe. Bank On certified accounts have no overdraft fees, need $25 or less to open, and are federally insured.'

> **TEACHING TIP**
>
> If a learner asks where to find a Bank On account locally, say you will follow up. The team is checking which nearby banks or credit unions offer one.

### SLIDE 4 -- Payday 2: Make Saving Automatic?

Class Vote

**Speaking Notes:**
Jess's employer can split her direct deposit so the same amount goes to savings every payday.

Expected answer: yes. If the class says no, Jess skips saving during a busy week on Payday 3 -- the class will see the difference on the meter.

Pop-up line to say: 'Set it once. Automatic saving does not depend on remembering or willpower.'

## SLIDE 5 -- Payday 2: Emergency or Planned?

Class Vote

**Speaking Notes:**
School picture day costs $30, and the form came home two weeks ago.

Expected answer: planned cost. An emergency is something you did not see coming. School pictures, birthdays, and car registration come every year, so they belong in the weekly plan, not the cushion.

> **DISCUSSION PROMPT**
> Ask: 'What other costs come every year that we could plan for?'

# P CHAPTER 4: PAYDAYS 3 AND 4

PRACTICE

## SLIDE 6 -- Payday 3: Flat Tire

Story Event

**Speaking Notes:**
No vote here. The screen applies this week's saving, then a $60 flat tire hits.

If the cushion covered it, point out what that prevented: no late rent, no borrowing, no missed shift. If Jess came up short, note that a slightly bigger cushion would have covered it.

Pop-up line to say: 'Families with $250 to $749 saved were less likely to be evicted or miss a housing or utility payment after a money shock.' (Urban Institute, April 2016)

## SLIDE 7 -- Payday 3: The SNAP Question

Class Vote

**Speaking Notes:**
A friend tells Jess that saving will cost her SNAP. Choices: stop saving, keep it quiet, or ask her caseworker how savings affects her benefits.

Expected answer: ask her caseworker.

Pop-up line to say: 'In West Virginia, SNAP lists no limit on savings for most households. WV WORKS is different: it counts savings, so check with a caseworker.' (USDA FNS, June 2026)

> **TEACHING TIP**
> If a learner asks about their own benefits, thank them and point them to their caseworker. Do not give eligibility advice, and do not quote a WV WORKS dollar limit -- the team has not verified the current figure.

## SLIDE 8 -- Payday 4: Tax Refund

Class Vote

**Speaking Notes:**
Jess's $1,200 refund arrives. Choices: $0, $100, $300, or $600 to savings first.

Any amount above $0 is a good answer. The point is deciding before the money is spent.

Pop-up line to say: 'You can split a federal refund into up to three accounts, including savings, when you e-file or with Form 8888.' (IRS)

# E CHAPTER 5: EVALUATION -- HOW IT WENT

## EVALUATION

### SLIDE 9 -- How It Went

Results

**Speaking Notes:**

The screen shows Jess's final cushion, what helped, and what held her back. Read the one-sentence idea at the bottom aloud.

Use the class's votes during the game as evidence of understanding. Learners who chose save-first, a safe account, automation, and asking a caseworker have met the objective.

**DISCUSSION PROMPT**

Ask: 'Which one choice made the biggest difference for Jess?' Listen for: saving first or making it automatic.

**TEACHING TIP**

Short on time? Skip the discussion and move to Your Turn. Want to show the contrast? Press Play again and make the opposite choices -- it takes about two minutes.

# A CHAPTER 6: APPLICATION -- YOUR TURN

APPLICATION

## SLIDE 10 -- Your Turn: My First Step

Personal Commitment

**Speaking Notes:**

Each learner picks one first step for this week:

1. Pick an amount to save first each payday
2. Open a safe place for savings
3. Set up one automatic transfer or split deposit
4. Ask my caseworker one question about saving
5. Plan part of my tax refund before it arrives

Learners with devices can open the game and use this screen privately. Everyone else uses the paper card. The amount line is optional, and cards are not collected.

**HANDOUT** My First Step card -- one per learner.

**TEACHING TIP**

One-on-one or virtual: the learner plays the same page alone while you talk through each pop-up. Share your screen for virtual groups and take votes in the chat.

# Materials Checklist

Print Before Class

| | Resource | Location |
|---|---|---|
| [ ] | The Cushion Challenge (HTML) | lesson-Money-Management/cushion-challenge.html |
| [ ] | Projector, smart board, or shared screen | Open the game and press Start over |
| [ ] | Speakers for the Meet Jess video | Video and captions play inside the game |
| [ ] | My First Step card | Paper version in progress; use the game's last screen until then |
| [ ] | Part 2 Lesson Plan | Teacher-Resources folder |
| [ ] | Pens or pencils | For paper cards |

Note: All resources are available in the Handouts folder and linked in the presentation sidebar under Resources.